ACTION TOOL 40

Building an incinerator for medical waste

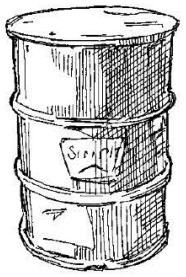
Overview

- In some epidemics, you will need to prevent germs on items (such as bed sheets and clothes that have been contaminated by the patient's body fluids) from spreading to other people.
- This is especially important when you are dealing with Ebola , Marburg fever , Lassa Fever , plague , and monkeypox .
- An incinerator can burn such items and prevent the disease from spreading to others.
- Do not incinerate items yourself if an alternative is available, such as incineration in health facilities.
- Be very careful when building and using incinerators, because they can be dangerous. Always have to hand something to put the fire out (for example, a bucket of water or sand).

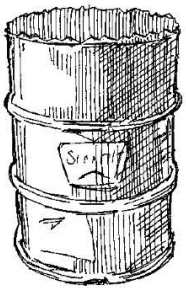
Tips for building an incinerator

- Keep a bucket of water or sand by you in case you need to put the fire out.
- If you have never built an incinerator before, ask a professional or someone who has already built one to help or advise you.
- Wear protective clothing, in particular gloves, when handling contaminated clothing or other items belonging to a deceased person. Place items carefully in the incinerator and leave them to burn until they have turned to ash, destroying all the germs.
- Tell people in the community what you are doing so that they know to stay away and keep safe.

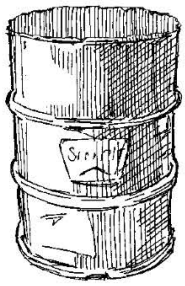
STEPS FOR BUILDING AN INCINERATOR



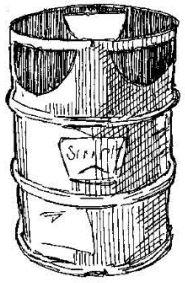
1. Find a 220 litre (55 gallon) drum.



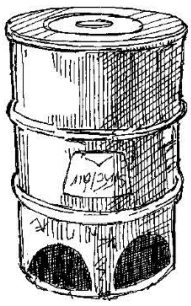
2. Cut open the drum. Remove and save the top cutaway piece.



3. Hammer the edges of the drum so that they are no longer sharp.

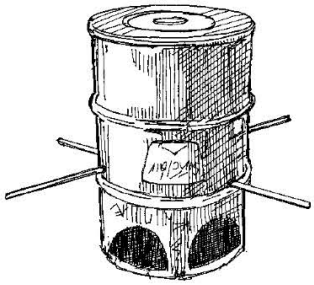


4. Cut 3 half-moon openings just above the top end of the drum.

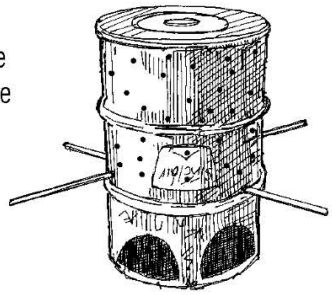


5. Turn the drum upside down. The bottom of the drum becomes the top.

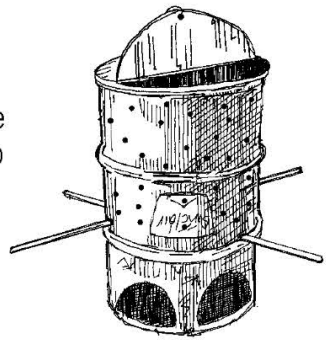
6. Cut 4 holes in the sides of the drum. Thread 2 metal rods through these holes so that they cross inside the drum.



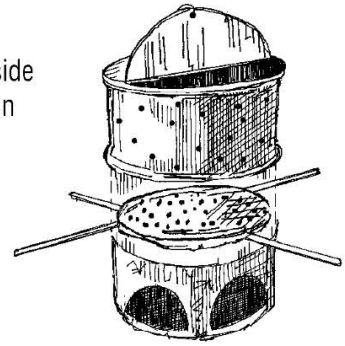
7. Punch holes in the top cutaway piece to make a platform.



8. Pierce a series of holes in the side of the drum, above the crossed rods to improve the draw of the fire.



9. Cut away half of the top. Attach the wire loops to the cutaway half to make a trap door. Attach another loop for a handle to open the trap door.



10. Place the platform (7) inside the drum so that it rests on the crossed rods.